airguides



SMALL-GROUP OCEAN EXPEDITION

Mexico: Swim with Striped Marlin & Sea Lions

Five full days on the water in Magdalena Bay with Karim Iliya. Enter the world of marlin, sea lions, seabirds and swirling sardine bait balls, with just five guests.

DATE	DURATION	GROUP SIZE	PRICE
23-29 Nov 2026	7 Days / 6 Nights	Max 5 Guests	US$3,600

HIGHLIGHTS

The sardine run, from inside the action

01

Five Days on the Water

Head offshore each morning with Karim and a local captain, scanning the blue for feeding action.

02

Five Guests Only

An intimate group means personal guidance, space in the water and time to work on your photography.

03

Striped Marlin

Watch striped marlin slice through dense sardine bait balls in one of the ocean's fastest hunts.

04

Sea Lions & Seabirds

See sea lions and seabirds join the feeding frenzy, with dolphins, rays and other pelagic wildlife also possible.

05

Karim Iliya

Get in-water support in photography, storytelling and underwater ethics from a world-class wildlife filmmaker.

06

Magdalena Island Camp

Stay six nights in safari-style tents on remote Magdalena Island, with every meal included.

ABOUT THE EXPERIENCE

A feeding event found almost nowhere else

Every year, sardines gather off Mexico's Magdalena Bay and draw striped marlin, sea lions and seabirds into a high-speed hunt.

Each morning starts early. You will head offshore with Karim and a local captain, reading the surface for signs of activity. When the moment comes, you enter with snorkel gear and meet the action at eye level.

Some encounters are a flash of marlin in the blue. Others place you beside a bait ball as predators work from every direction. The animals decide what happens next, and the team follows strict guidelines to keep each interaction ethical and respectful.

Karim is beside you in the water and behind the lens, helping you make stronger images without losing sight of the experience itself.



Wildlife encounters are never guaranteed. That unpredictability is exactly what makes them wild.

"Swimming with marlins, sea lions and other animals is a transformative experience. We strive to share it in an intimate, respectful and engaging way."

Karim Iliya, Storyteller Guide

YOUR STORYTELLER GUIDE

Karim Iliya



Karim Iliya

WILDLIFE PHOTOGRAPHER, FILMMAKER AND CONSERVATIONIST

Karim's work offers a rare glimpse into the lives of some of Earth's most compelling species. From swimming with whales to documenting volcanic eruptions from above, his images have appeared in National Geographic, BBC Earth and other leading publications.

His approach combines technical mastery with patience, instinct and respect for the natural world. In Magdalena Bay, he offers one-on-one support in photography, storytelling and underwater ethics, whether you are an experienced shooter or using a camera underwater for the first time.

> *"Photography lets me see the Earth in a new way, where I take my time looking at the details." - Karim Iliya*



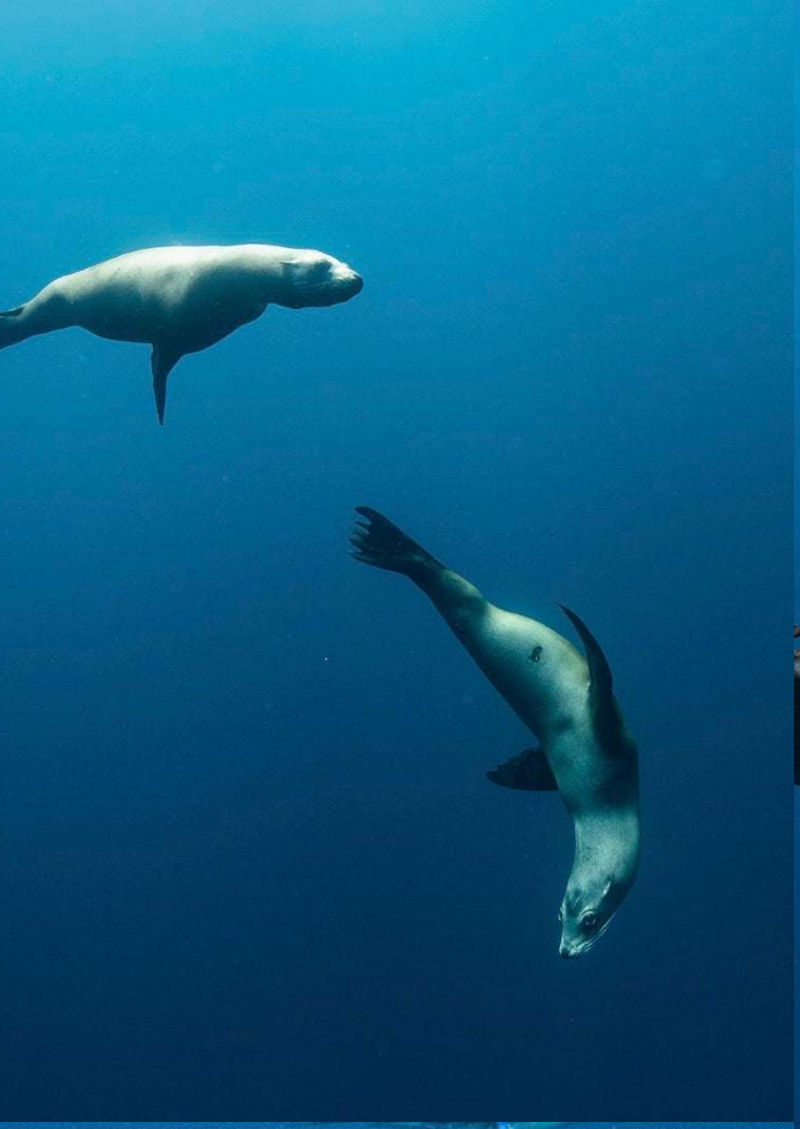
WHY THIS TRIP?

Five days to follow the ocean, not a timetable

The sardine run is fast, raw and unpredictable. Repeated days offshore create time to read the conditions and be ready when the bay comes alive.

The local captain and crew know these waters. Karim understands both pelagic wildlife behaviour and what it takes to make purposeful underwater images. The five-guest maximum keeps the experience personal.

This is open-ocean snorkelling, not a staged wildlife encounter. The boat remains close, the crew monitors conditions, and the animals dictate every interaction.






DAY BY DAY

Your 7-day Magdalena Bay expedition

DAY 1

Arrival & Transfer to Magdalena Island

ARRIVAL

Meet the group in La Paz around midday, then drive about four hours south through the Baja landscape to Puerto San Carlos. A short boat crossing takes you to Magdalena Island. Settle into camp, share dinner and gather for the trip briefing. Airguides recommends arriving via La Paz or Los Cabos the day before.

DAYS 2–6

Ocean Swim Days

5 FULL DAYS

Start early, head offshore after breakfast and scan with Karim and the local captain for striped marlin, sea lions and sardine bait balls. Enter the water when conditions and wildlife behaviour allow. Return to camp in the afternoon to rest, then share stories, highlights and dinner at the Palapa.

DAY 7

Departure

DEPARTURE

Depart between 7:00 and 8:00 AM for the return drive to La Paz. If flying from San Jose del Cabo, Airguides recommends booking a flight after 4:00 PM or staying an extra night.

YOUR BASE

Six nights on Magdalena Island

Safari-style tents put you close to the water and the rhythms of the sardine run.

Shared occupancy is standard, with private tent upgrades available on request for an additional fee. Breakfast is served at camp, packed lunches and snacks go out on the boat, and the group returns for dinner in the evening.

The camp is remote, clean and comfortable, designed for the setting rather than distraction. Afternoons give you time to rest, recover and review the day's images before the next early start.



6	5	5	1
nights on the island	full days on the water	guest maximum	wild feeding event

THE DETAILS

What's included

Included

- Five full days on the water with striped marlin, sea lions and other marine life
- Six nights shared safari-style camp accommodation on Magdalena Island
- Breakfasts, packed lunches and dinners
- Experienced local captain and crew
- In-water guidance and underwater photography support from Karim Iliya
- Photography masterclasses with Karim
- Professional trip photos from Karim, shared after the trip
- Overland and boat transfers from La Paz to Magdalena Island and return

Optional extra: a private tent may be available for a single supplement. Contact Airguides for current pricing.

Not Included

- Flights to and from Baja California
- Snorkelling gear, including your own mask, snorkel, fins and wetsuit
- Camera equipment
- Travel and in-water insurance, which is mandatory
- Alcoholic drinks and personal extras
- Optional activities outside the listed itinerary

Wildlife encounters are never guaranteed. Weather and ocean conditions can affect the itinerary.

FAQ

What guests usually need to know

How strong a swimmer do I need to be?

You need to be a confident snorkeller in open water, but you do not need to be an elite swimmer. The boat stays close and the crew monitors conditions throughout.

What are the water conditions in November?

Water temperatures are typically 27 to 29 degrees Celsius, with average visibility of 10 to 15 metres. A 3 to 5mm wetsuit is recommended for longer sessions.

Is wildlife guaranteed?

No. The expedition centres on the sardine run, but sightings of any species cannot be guaranteed. Weather, ocean conditions and wildlife behaviour determine each day.

What gear should I bring?

Bring your own mask, snorkel, fins and wetsuit. No snorkelling gear is provided or available for hire. For photography, bring the camera setup you know best. A laptop with Adobe Lightroom can be useful for editing.

How do I get there?

Fly into La Paz International Airport or Los Cabos International Airport. The trip starts and ends in La Paz, with overland and boat transfers to Magdalena Island included from there.

What insurance is required?

Comprehensive in-water coverage is mandatory. Your policy must cover open-ocean snorkelling, medical expenses and emergency evacuation.

PRICING & DATES

One intimate November departure

TRIP PRICE

US$3,600

Per person in USD for seven days and six nights in Mexico.

GROUP SIZE

5 Max

A deliberately small group for personal guidance and respectful in-water encounters.

23 November to 29 November 2026 (Confirmed)

Availability, payment options and private tent supplements should be confirmed with Airguides at the time of booking.

READY?

Five days on the water. Five guests. One of the ocean's fastest hunts.

Get in touch to check availability, talk through flights and prepare for Magdalena Bay.

Check Dates & Availability

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